

8.b) How did Boas's ideas challenge the prevailing theories of unilineal cultural evolution, and what were the implications for anthropological research? (15 marks)

Franz Boas belonged to the American diffusionist school. His primary work were:

- Kwakiuth Text (1905)
- Limitations of Comparative Approach in Anthropology (1896)

Criticism of prevailing theories of unilineal evolution

- ① He said unilineal evolutionists as unscientific ⇒ Based on secondary data
- ② Idea of 3 stage evolution ⇒ Based on ethnocentrism
- ③ Criticized idea of Psychic unity of Mankind as no empirical basis.
- ④ Comparing cultures is crude method
- ⑤ Grand laws of evolution couldn't be formed as cultural traits change in different context.

Method to challenge prevailing theory of evolution

① Proposed method of "Historical Particularism"

② Cultures must be studied in their own cultural context based on own circumstances.

③ For this he proposed collection of historical data → Relating it to the spread of cultural trait can help understand diffusion of and formation of culture area.

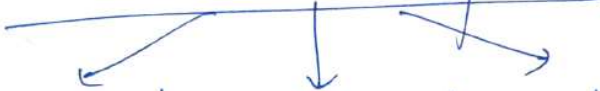
④ Intensive fieldwork with data on every aspect must be collected.

⑤ Proposed idea of cultural relativism where culture must be studied in their own context based on own values.

⑥ ~~Howe~~ Against formation of grand theories of evolution

Implications of work in anthropological research

- ① It moved anthropology away from grand theory building
- ② Cultural Relativism became hallmark for anthropological research.
- ③ 3 factors for determining culture.



Environment

Historical
connection

Individual
context.
- ④ Provided guidance to female anthropologists
 - ↳ New viewpoints brought
 - eg → Ruth Benedict, M. Mead in culture-personality schools

- ⑤ Issue with work
 - (a) → Difficult to replicate
 - (b) → Marvin Harris use of collecting so much data if no theory formed.

In conclusion, Boas's work enriched the field of anthropology with new methods which guided its future.